

FILE ID: MDE-72H-PROT

MEDELLÍN SURVIVAL VAULT



THE FIRST 72 HOURS PROTOCOL

Tactical Guidance for the City of Eternal Spring. Beware of the Mirage. Beware of “The Prettiest Things”.

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MEDELLÍN SURVIVAL VAULT

THE FIRST 72 HOURS PROTOCOL

WARNING: THE MIRAGE IS REAL.

Unlike Bogotá (cold and indifferent) or Cartagena (hot and aggressive), Medellín is seductive. The weather is perfect. The people are incredibly friendly. The streets of El Poblado look like Miami.

This is the trap. Our Local Intel defines Medellín with one concept: **The Mirage.**

- “The nicer the street, the more dangerous it is.”
- “The more elegant the thief, the deadlier they are.”

In Medellín, danger doesn't always look like a thug; it often looks like a model on Tinder or a well-dressed gentleman speaking perfect English. The threat here is not confrontation; it is overconfidence.

THE OPERATIONAL DIRECTIVE: “NO DES PAPAYA”

It is the only law that matters. It means: Don't make yourself a target. Don't flash the iPhone. Don't trust the sudden friendliness of strangers. Don't assume safety just because the area looks “rich.”

This Vault contains the extracted intelligence to navigate the “Lomas” (hills), identify the “Gomelo” thieves, and enjoy the best nightlife in the world without becoming a statistic.

FILE ID: MDE-72H-PROT

**Your mission: Read. Execute.
Adapt.**

**Welcome to the City of Eternal
Spring.**

Don't let it put you to sleep.

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PROCEED TO CHAPTER 1

01. THE MOUNTAIN DESCENT

(ARRIVAL)

Airport Logistics, The “Colectivo” Hack & The Front Seat.

Welcome to José María Córdova (JMC) Airport. First operational reality: You are not in Medellín yet. You are in Rionegro, high in the Andes. The city is 45 minutes down a winding mountain tunnel.

Your arrival strategy dictates the tone of your trip. Our Local Intel Asset emphasizes one rule for this phase: **Low Profile.**

1. LUGGAGE & VISUAL DISCIPLINE

In Medellín, risk is often calculated by appearance.

- **The “Mark” Logic:** Thieves in the airport area don’t look like thugs; they blend in. They look for brand names, excessive luggage, and distracted travelers.
- **The Protocol:**
 - Keep your bags within physical reach at all times.
 - Don’t flash luxury items (watches, jewelry) immediately upon arrival.
 - Dress comfortably and simply. The goal is to blend in, not to stand out as a “high-value target.”

2. TRANSPORT HIERARCHY

You have three options to descend the mountain. Choose based on your budget and street smarts.

OPTION A: THE WHITE TAXI (The Standard)

- **What is it:** Official airport taxis (White & Blue).
- **Cost:** ~110,000 - 120,000 COP (\$28 - \$30 USD). Includes toll fees.
- **Pros:** Safe, private, direct to your door.
- **Cons:** Expensive for a solo traveler.

OPTION B: THE “COLECTIVO” (The Local Hack)

- **Intel:** Most tourists don't know this exists. You can share a white taxi with 3 other people.
- **Location:** Turn LEFT immediately after exiting the sliding doors. Look for the sign “Taxis Colectivos.”
- **Cost:** ~27,000 - 30,000 COP per person (\$7 USD).
- **Destination on Sign:** “San Diego Mall”.
- **THE REALITY CHECK:** It does NOT enter the Mall. It drops you at the San Diego Bridge (a busy highway interchange next to the mall). Do not expect a lobby; expect the street.

OPTION C: THE BUS (The Budget Move)

- **Location:** Turn RIGHT after exiting.
- **Cost:** ~14,000 - 16,000 COP (\$4 USD).
- **Risk:** You are separated from your luggage (it goes below). Keep eyes on the storage compartment during stops.
- **The Drop Zone:** Same as the Colectivo—The San Diego Bridge.

3. THE SAN DIEGO MANEUVER (CRITICAL)

If you take Option B or C, you will land on the street under or near the bridge.

- **The Trap:** Do **NOT** hail a random taxi under the bridge. It is chaotic, dark at night, and vulnerable.
- **The “Extension” Negotiation:**
 - *The Move:* Before getting out of the Colectivo, ask the driver: “*Parce, ¿por cuánto me llevas hasta el hotel? Te encimo algo.*” (Friend, how much to take me to the hotel? I’ll add extra).
 - *The Win:* Often, for an extra 15k-20k COP, they will skip the bridge drop-off and take you direct to your door. Safe and efficient.
- **The “Walk-In” Protocol:**
 - If the driver says no, grab your bags and walk across the bridge directly into the **San Diego Mall**.
 - Once inside the Mall (Safe Zone), order your Uber or take a mall taxi from the official rank.

4. THE “FRONT SEAT” PROTOCOL (SOCIAL CAMOUFLAGE)

In many cities, sitting in the back is standard. In Medellín, it creates a barrier. Locals (Paisas) value closeness and egalitarianism.

THE RULE: Always sit in the front. Whether it’s a Taxi or an Uber/Rideshare.

- **The Psychology:** Sitting in the back signals “I am a foreign client.” Sitting in the front signals “I am a friend (Parce).”

- **The Benefit:** A driver who sees you as a friend is more likely to protect you, give you honest advice, and charge you fairly. A driver who sees you as a distant tourist will simply extract money from you.
- **The Interaction:** Fist bump the driver when you enter. Say “*¿Qué más, bien o qué?*”. Break the ice immediately.

NEXT STEP: You are in the valley.
Now you need to understand why the danger here is invisible.

PROCEED TO CHAPTER 02.

02. CAMOUFLAGE & THREATS

The “Gomelo” Thief, Visual Discipline & RFID Skimming.

In most cities, you are trained to avoid the “rough” looking characters. In Medellín, that instinct will fail you.

Our Local Intel confirms a disturbing reality: **“The better dressed the thief, the more dangerous they are.”**

1. THE “GOMELO” THIEF (THE PREPPY THREAT)

In Colombian slang, a “Gomelo” is a preppy, rich kid. In the criminal underworld of Medellín, the most effective thieves adopt this aesthetic to infiltrate high-end zones (Poblado, Provenza, Laureles).

- **The Camouflage:** They wear designer clothes (often fake or stolen), nice sneakers, and look like university students or young entrepreneurs. They sit next to you at the Starbucks or the coworking space.
- **The Tactic:** They rely on your bias. You lower your guard because they “look like you.”
- **The Counter-Measure:** Stop judging safety by appearance. Treat the well-dressed guy standing too close to you with the same tactical awareness as you would a street thug.

2. VISUAL DISCIPLINE (THE WATCH RULE)

Medellín has a specific criminal market for high-end watches and jewelry. There are specialized gangs (“Los Roleros”) who spot targets in restaurants and follow them.

THE HARD RULE: Do not wear a Rolex, Patek, or any expensive watch in Medellín. Not even in the “safest” restaurant. Not even in the Uber.

- **The Reality:** It is a beacon. It screams “Target.”
- **The Fix:** Wear a Casio, an Apple Watch (low risk), or nothing at all. Leave the jewelry in the hotel safe.
- **“No Dar Papaya”:** This is the Golden Rule of Colombia. It translates to “Don’t give the Papaya.” Meaning: Don’t present an easy opportunity. Walking around with a \$5,000 watch is the ultimate Papaya.

3. DIGITAL PICKPOCKETING (RFID SKIMMING)

Violent muggings are bad for business. Modern thieves prefer technology. Our Intel reports a rise in **Wireless Skimming** in crowded tourist areas (Provenza, Lleras).

- **The Modus Operandi:** A “Gomelo” thief or a well-dressed woman bumps into you in a crowd or stands pressed against you in a line.
- **The Tech:** They have a **portable card terminal (POS)** concealed in a bag or pocket. They tap it against your pocket where your wallet is.
- **The Result:** A contactless transaction is approved instantly. You don’t realize it until you check your bank app.

- **The Defense:**

1. **RFID Blocking Wallet:** Essential gear for Medellín.
2. **Front Pocket Protocol:** Keep your wallet in your front pocket, hand over it in crowds.
3. **Transaction Limits:** Set low limits for contactless payments on your banking app before you fly.

4. THE “SPOTTER” (EL CAMPANERO)

Rarely does a thief work alone. If you are eating on a terrace in El Poblado:

- **Target A:** The person selling candy/cigarettes might be a harmless vendor.
- **Target B:** They might be a “Campanero” (Bell-ringer/ Spotter) checking your wrist for a watch or your table for an iPhone.
- **The Protocol:** If a street vendor lingers too long looking at your gear, move. Pay the bill and change locations. Trust your gut.

NEXT STEP: You know the enemy camouflage. Now, let’s map the territory. Why is the “Rich Neighborhood” actually the danger zone?

PROCEED TO CHAPTER 03.

03. THE TERRITORY PARADOX

The “Poblado” Trap & The Safety of the Barrios.

In almost every city in the world, the rule is simple:

- *Rich Neighborhood = Safe.*
- *Poor Neighborhood = Dangerous.*

In Medellín, this rule is inverted. Our Local Intel calls this “The Mirage.”

1. THE “POBLADO” HUNTING GROUND

El Poblado (specifically Provenza, Parque Lleras, and the “Golden Mile”) is the wealthiest district. It looks like Miami: lush greenery, high-rise luxury apartments, and expensive SUVs.

The Reality: It is the **#1 Hunting Ground** for theft in the city.

- **The Logic:** Thieves are smart businessmen. They go where the product is.
 - Where are the \$1,000 iPhones? **El Poblado.**
 - Where are the Rolexes? **El Poblado.**
 - Where are the tourists carrying dollars? **El Poblado.**
- **The Effect:** If you are walking in Provenza at night, you are not just a pedestrian; you are “inventory.” The concentration of predators (pickpockets, scammers, and “scopolamine” workers) is higher here than anywhere else.

2. THE “BARRIO” CODE (THE PAX MAFIOSA)

Paradoxically, many working-class or traditional neighborhoods (like Envigado, Sabaneta, or residential zones) operate under a different set of rules.

- **Community Policing:** In traditional barrios, the community (and often local groups) enforces a strict “No Robbery” code within their territory. A thief who robs a neighbor or a visitor in a local barrio faces “social correction” (which is often violent).
- **The Vibe:** In Envigado (a separate municipality technically, but integrated), you will see locals sitting outside, doors open, relaxed. The “tension” of El Poblado disappears.
- **Intel Note:** Our source confirms: “In the barrio, you are a person. In El Poblado, you are a target.”

3. THE “UBER HOP” RULE

How do you survive the Poblado Paradox? Distance is irrelevant. Safety is binary.

- **In El Poblado/Lleras:**
 - Do not walk 5 blocks back to your hotel at 2:00 AM, even if the street looks pretty and leafy.
 - **The Protocol:** Order an Uber. Wait inside the restaurant/bar until it arrives. Hop in. Hop out at your hotel lobby.
 - *Why:* The “dark stretches” between illuminated bars are where the “motorcycle snatchers” operate.

- **In Laureles/Envigado:**
 - These areas are more walkable, wide boulevards (Laureles) or town squares (Envigado).
 - **Caution:** Laureles is becoming “The New Poblado.” As more tourists arrive, the predators are following. It is currently “Yellow Alert” (Caution), whereas El Poblado is “Red Alert” (High Threat).

4. THE INVISIBLE BORDERS

Medellín changes block by block.

- **Downtown (El Centro):** During the day (Botero Plaza), it is chaotic but manageable (High Pickpocket Risk). **At night (after 6:00 PM), it is a No-Go Zone.** The streets empty out, and it becomes extremely dangerous for a solo tourist.
- **The “Mirage” Boundary:** You might be in a safe street in Manila (El Poblado), cross one avenue, and end up in a desolate mechanic district.
- **Navigation Rule:** If the street lights change from “Warm/Bright” to “Dark/Yellow,” or if the street vendors disappear, **turn around.**

NEXT STEP: You know where to walk. Now you need to know who to talk to. The friendly stranger is the biggest threat.

PROCEED TO CHAPTER 04.

04. SOCIAL ENGINEERING (THE HONEY POT)

The Clock Tower, The Walls & The Hard Deck.

Medellín is famous for the warmth of its people. This is the city's greatest asset, but for a tourist, it can also be a blind spot.

In other cities, you are trained to watch out for aggression. In Medellín, you need to watch out for **seduction and overconfidence**. The risk here isn't usually a confrontation; it's letting your guard down because everyone seems so nice.

Our **Local Intel** puts it simply: *“If something seems too good to be true—like a sudden intense romance or a stranger insisting on buying you expensive drinks—it probably is.”*

1. THE “TINDER” PROTOCOL

Dating apps (Tinder, Bumble) in Medellín are not just for dating; they are hunting grounds for organized gangs.

- **The Trap:** You match with someone “out of your league.” They are incredibly eager to meet you *tonight*. They suggest coming to your Airbnb or hotel.
- **The Reality:** This is a robbery setup.

- **The Rules of Engagement:**

1. **Neutral Ground:** ALWAYS meet in a public place (a mall, a busy restaurant in **El Poblado** or Laureles).
2. **No Home Visits:** NEVER bring a stranger to your apartment on the first date. Security cameras in your building will not stop them from drugging you once inside.
3. **The “ID” Check:** It sounds paranoid, but it saves lives. If things go well, take a picture of their ID and send it to a friend in front of them. If they get angry or refuse, abort immediately.

2. THE “CUCHO” TRAP (THE GENTLEMAN)

We often warn about “beautiful women,” but our Intel highlights a specific, less obvious threat: **The Well-Dressed Older Man.**

- **The Scenario:** You are in a coffee shop or bar. A well-dressed older gentleman (a “Cucho” in local slang) approaches you. He speaks perfect English.
- **The Hook:** He claims he was just robbed, or he lost his wallet, or he wants to practice English. He builds rapport. He buys you a drink or offers you gum/cigarettes.
- **The Result:** The item is spiked. You wake up 24 hours later with empty bank accounts.
- **Defense:** Be polite but distant. Do not accept anything consumable from a stranger, no matter how “harmless” or elderly they look.

3. DRINK SAFETY (STANDARD PROTOCOL)

In any major nightlife capital—from Miami to Ibiza—keeping an eye on your drink is standard procedure. Medellín is no exception.

- **The Risk:** Unattended drinks are vulnerable.
- **The Rule:** Control your glass.
- **The Protocol:**
 - **The “Barman” Rule:** Watch your drink being poured. Only accept drinks directly from the staff or your trusted group.
 - **The Stranger Factor:** If a stranger offers to buy you a drink, politely decline or ask them to order it at the bar while you watch.
 - **The Buddy System:** If you suddenly feel dizzy or unusually intoxicated after just one drink, do NOT go outside for “fresh air” alone. Alert your friend or the security staff immediately and stay inside the venue.

4. THE “TOO FRIENDLY” RED FLAG

Paisas are naturally friendly, but there is a limit.

- **The Mirage:** If a group of locals suddenly invites you to their table, treats you like a king, and insists on buying bottles for you... **Pause.**
- **The Calculus:** Ask yourself: *“Why are these strangers spending \$200 USD on me?”*
- **The Action:** Appreciate the gesture, decline the drink, and move on. Real friendship in Medellín takes time; instant aggressive friendship is often a strategy.

NEXT STEP: You know who to avoid. Now let's map where to go. The difference between “Bangkok” and “Local Cool”.

PROCEED TO CHAPTER 05.

05. NIGHT OPERATIONS

(MAPPING THE PARTY)

Tourist Traps (Lleras) vs. The Local Circuit (Astorga).

Medellín's nightlife is legendary, but it is divided into two very different worlds just blocks apart. One is famous but exhausted. The other is where the city actually lives.

1. THE HIGH-INTENSITY ZONE: PARQUE LLERAS

Parque Lleras is the most famous spot in travel guides, but for locals, it has become a "Tourist Extraction Zone."

- **The Atmosphere:** It is incredibly intense. It is loud, crowded, and commercial.
- **The Hassle Factor:** You will be approached constantly. Street rappers, vendors selling gum/cigarettes, and people offering "services" will interrupt your conversation every 2 minutes.
- **The Verdict:** It is an iconic spot to see once, but if you want a relaxed drink, good music, or a genuine conversation, this is not the place. It is a high-friction environment.

2. THE LOCAL FAVORITE: THE ASTORGA CIRCUIT

Just a few blocks away from Lleras (near Parque del Poblado) lies **Astorga**. This is where the creative class, expats-in-the-know, and locals prefer to hang out.

- **The Vibe:** It is curated. Better design, better cocktails, and significantly less street hassle.
- **Intel Approved Spots:**
 - **El Social:** A traditional corner store turned into a bar. Perfect for a casual beer and watching the city go by.
 - **Café Dragón:** A favorite for a more upscale, cool atmosphere.
 - **7 Pulgadas:** A listening bar for audiophiles. Vinyl records and great drinks.
 - **Salón Amador:** Electronic music without the chaos.

3. THE AUTHENTIC ZONE: LAURELES (LA 70)

If you want to experience how *Paisas* actually party (Salsa, Vallenato, and Aguardiente), you go to **Laureles**.

- **La 70 (The Strip):** It is a long avenue full of bars with open facades. It is loud and energetic, but it feels “real.”
- **The Parks:** The areas around the 1st and 2nd Parks of Laureles offer a European-style cafe culture mixed with Colombian warmth. Very walkable and safe for dining.

4. THE “AFTER PARTY” DECISION

The Golden Rule: The best parties happen in public venues.

- **The Scenario:** You meet a group of new friends at a club, and at 3:00 AM, someone suggests moving the party to a private farm (finca) or an unknown apartment.
- **The Protocol:** Decline and go home.

- **Why:** Leaving a public, controlled environment to go to a secondary location with strangers is a tactical error. It removes you from safety networks and transport options. Keep the fun in the city, where you have control.

NEXT STEP: Understanding the economics of your trip. How to handle the bill and the hills.

PROCEED TO CHAPTER 06.

06. LOGISTICS & ECONOMY

The Inflation, The Hills & The Bill.

Medellín is a cosmopolitan hub, and prices in tourist zones now reflect that. While still affordable compared to Miami or London, it is no longer the ultra-cheap backpacker secret it was a decade ago. Understanding the terrain and the economy will save you sweat and money.

1. NAVIGATING THE “LOMAS” (THE HILLS)

El Poblado is built on the side of a steep mountain. This is a critical logistical detail that maps often hide.

- **The Map Illusion:** You might look at Google Maps and see your destination is only 4 blocks away.
- **The Reality:** Those 4 blocks might be a **45-degree vertical climb**.
- **The Strategy:**
 - **Downhill:** Walkable, pleasant, and great for sightseeing.
 - **Uphill:** In the heat of the day (or if you want to arrive at dinner without sweating through your shirt), take a taxi or Uber for short distances. It costs \$3 USD and saves your energy.

2. THE PRICE REALITY (“GENTRIFICATION”)

Don’t be shocked if a dinner in El Poblado costs the same as a dinner in a major US city.

- **The “Cool” Premium:** In areas like Provenza or Astorga, a burger and a cocktail can easily run ~90,000 COP (\$22 USD).
- **The Value Play:** If you want better value, head to Laureles or Envigado. The quality of food is often just as high (or better), but the prices are significantly lower because they cater more to locals than tourists.

3. THE “MENU” PROTOCOL (BILL SAFETY)

A common friction point for travelers is the final bill at nightlife venues.

- **The Scenario:** You order a “special” drink or a bottle recommended by a waiter without asking the price.
- **The Surprise:** The bill arrives, and it is much higher than expected.
- **The Rule:** Always check the menu.
- **The Habit:** If a server suggests a special item, simply ask: “¿Qué precio tiene?” (What is the price?) before saying yes. It eliminates confusion and prevents the feeling of being overcharged later.
- **Tipping:** In Colombia, the tip (“Servicio”) is voluntary, usually 10%. They will ask: “¿Desea incluir el servicio?”. It is polite to say yes if the service was good, but you are not obligated to pay more than that.

4. CASH VS. CARD

- **Cards:** Credit cards are accepted in almost all restaurants, malls, and chain stores in El Poblado and Laureles.
- **Cash (“Efectivo”):** Essential for:
 - Street food (Arepas, Mangos, Obleas).
 - Small taxis.
 - Tipping street performers or helpers.
- **The “Small Bill” Logic:** Try to break big bills (\$50,000 or \$100,000 COP) at large supermarkets or restaurants. Taxi drivers and small vendors often struggle to make change for a short ride. Keep a stash of \$2k, \$5k, and \$10k bills for easy transactions.

NEXT STEP: The final briefing. A summary of the mindset you need to enjoy the city safely.

PROCEED TO CHAPTER 07.

07. MANIFESTO & EMERGENCY

INTEL

“Beware of the Prettiest Things” & The Safety Net.

We asked our Local Intel for one final piece of advice to print on a sign for every tourist arriving in Medellín. His answer was cryptic but essential:

THE MANIFESTO: “CUIDADO CON LO MÁS LINDO”
(Translation: Beware of the prettiest things.)
Medellín is a city of mirrors.

- The most dangerous thief often dresses better than you.
- The most dangerous street often has the nicest trees.
- The most dangerous offer often comes with the friendliest smile.

The Directive: If something feels too easy, too fast, or too perfect... Pause. Enjoy the beauty, enjoy the party, but keep one foot in reality. Don't let the “Mirage” put you to sleep.

EMERGENCY ASSETS (SAVE THIS)

If the “Mirage” breaks and you need help, go to these specific locations. Do not just go to “any hospital.”

1. MEDICAL EXTRACTION (TOP TIER CLINICS)

If you get sick, injured, or feel intoxicated:

- **ZONE: EL POBLADO (The Best Option)**
 - **TARGET:** Clínica El Rosario (Sede El Tesoro).
 - **Why:** Located inside a high-end mall complex (El Tesoro). It is modern, safe, and accustomed to treating international patients.
 - **Address:** Carrera 25A # 1A Sur - 45.
- **ZONE: AIRPORT / BELÉN / LAURELES**
 - **TARGET:** Clínica Las Américas.
 - **Why:** World-class infrastructure. It is the medical hub for the region. If it's a major trauma or complex emergency, go here.
 - **Address:** Diagonal 75B # 2A - 80.

2. DIPLOMATIC CONTACTS (MEDELLÍN)

Note: Most Embassies are located in Bogotá, but these Consular Agencies operate in Medellín for emergencies (lost passports, etc.).

- **USA (Consular Agency):**
 - **Location:** Centro Comercial Dann Carlton (El Poblado).
 - **Phone:** +57) 601 275-2000 (Connects to main mission, ask for Medellín agency).

- **UK (Honorary Consulate):**
 - **Email:** medellin@honorary.fcdo.gov.uk
- **FRANCE (Alliance Française):**
 - **Phone:** (+57) 604 444 2620.

3. THE NUCLEAR OPTION (POLICE)

- **National Emergency Line:**
 - 123 (Police, Ambulance, Fire).
- **Tourist Police:** Ask your hotel front desk to connect you immediately.

END OF PROTOCOL.

**WELCOME TO THE CITY OF
ETERNAL SPRING.**